on the national stage. The BJP has slowly but steadily begun wooing the NCP's sub-regional satraps—former legislators Rajan Patil Angarkar and Yashwant Mane (Solapur), and Deepak Salunkhe Patil and Dr Yogesh Kshirsagar (Beed)—into its fold.

In October, laying the foundation stone for the BJP's new office in Mumbai, Union home minister Amit Shah said the party has come into its own in Maharashtra and does not need any "crutches", creating a flutter in the NCP and Sena. Straws in the wind suggest that the BJP may be developing a caucus of MLAs within its alliance partners. Sena leader and former health minister Tanaji Sawant, who is upset at being kept out of the cabinet, has claimed that the events of 2022 [the split in the Sena by deputy CM Eknath Shinde] could repeat themselves. "This controversy is not a coincidence for sure. This has been timed with an eye on the local bodies election," explains a senior NCP leader. He points to how the BJP and NCP are in contention to seize power in urban centres like Pune and Pimpri Chinchwad, which are seeing a surge in land prices and massive investments in infrastructure projects.

The land deal controversy has coincided with Ajit making conciliatory noises towards his uncle Sharad Pawar, who heads another faction of the NCP, and acknowledging Pawar Sr's role in his political career. "Even I love him," he added for good measure. His cousin and NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) Lok Sabha MP from Baramati, Supriya Sule, has expressed faith that nephew Parth will not do anything wrong. Asked why grand-nephew Parth's name did not find a mention in the FIR, Pawar Sr asked Fadnavis, who is also the home minister, to clarify this. "If the CM says in public that this is a serious issue, then it must be probed and the facts must be placed in the public domain," he added, calling daughter Supriya's statement on Parth her personal opinion. At the same time, Pawar Sr has said that local units of the party could take local factors into consideration to strike alliances for the local body polls. The two NCPs are said to be in talks in areas like Pimpri Chinchwad, a former bastion where the BJP has made inroads.

UNEASY ALLIANCE

The NCP, which claims to be of secular stock, has been upset over the BJP's muscular assertion of Hindutva. For instance, after a video of some Muslim women offering namaz at the Shaniwarwada, the seat of power of the Peshwas in Pune, went viral in October, BJP Rajya Sabha MP Medha Kulkarni 'purified' the spot, to which NCP leader Rupali Patil Thombre protested. Thombre, however, was later dropped as the NCP spokesperson. In another instance reflecting the BJP's expansive writ, the induction of NCP veteran and OBC leader Chhagan Bhujbal into the cabinet in May was seen more as a BJP push than Ajit's preference. Bhujbal has rallied the OBCs against the Maratha demand for backward quotas, which has upset the NCP's core Maratha voters.

A Sena source notes how the BJP, which once accused the NCP of being a 'Naturally Corrupt Party' but broke bread with it in 2019 and 2023, is getting a taste of its own medicine. "Ajit Pawar is now a moral and political question mark over the BJP. They are looking very weak," he says. "The NCP will continue to be brazen and the BJP will continue to look helpless and pay the price for their moral compromises." ■

A SHADY LAND DEAL

How a colonial-era land grant has come to haunt Ajit Pawar

- **In the 19th century, the British grants over 40 acres** in Mundhwa to members of the Mahar community as Mahar *watan* lands, given in return for traditional village services
- **The Mahar Watan Abolition Act, 1950, abolishes these *watans*** and converts them into regular occupancy lands with restrictions on sale, transfer and use. To gain ownership, landholders have to pay *nazrana* (dues) to the govt
- **In the mid-1950s, the Bombay govt takes over the land** due to unpaid dues and later leases it to the Botanical Survey of India (BSI). The periodically renewed lease runs till 2038
- **In 2006, developer Sheetal Tejwani takes powers of attorney** from 272 descendants of the original 26 landowning families, allegedly promising to help them reclaim the land for sale or development. Some of these PoAs are notarised, but not registered
- **In May 2025, a sale deed is signed** between Amadea Enterprises LLP (Parth Pawar and his cousin Digvijay Amarsinh Patil hold 99% and 1% stakes respectively) and Tejwani
- **The deed values the land at Rs 300 crore**, though its market value is estimated at about Rs 1,800 crore. Just Rs 500 in stamp duty is paid—using a waiver meant for IT parks and data centres—instead of the Rs 21 crore otherwise due
- **In June, tehsildar Suryakant Yewale—now suspended**—issues a notice asking the BSI to vacate the land
- **On Nov. 6, sub-registrar Taru is suspended over lapses**; a probe is ordered by the CM and the sale deed is cancelled
- **On Nov. 7, an FIR is filed** against Patil, Tejwani and Taru without Parth's name in it